

THE UNFURNISHED APARTMENT

German flats come empty. Emptier than you think.

No kitchen. No lamps. Sometimes no floor. This is normal here, it is legal, and it is survivable — as long as nobody hands you the keys to a surprise.

1 The reality check

In most countries "unfurnished" means no sofa. In Germany it can mean **no kitchen at all** — bare walls, capped pipes, and a socket where an oven used to be.

The word you are looking for is **Einbauküche**, usually shortened to **EBK**. It means a fitted kitchen: cabinets, worktop, sink, and normally an oven and hob. If a listing does not say EBK, assume there is no kitchen.

Why is it like this? German tenants stay for years and traditionally buy their own kitchen and take it with them when they move. Landlords never had to provide one, so many still do not. The same logic applies to ceiling lamps and sometimes flooring.

What is commonly missing

Kitchen

Cabinets, sink, oven, hob

Light fixtures

Bare wires from the ceiling

Lampshades and bulbs

Even where a fitting exists

Wardrobes

Built-in closets are rare

Flooring

Occasionally bare screed

Curtains and rails

Almost always absent

The way out

Many outgoing tenants sell you their kitchen instead of removing it. This is called an **Abstandszahlung** — a transfer payment. A used EBK often costs €300–€1,500, far less than a new one. Always ask whether the current tenant wants to sell.

Read this before you sign

If you take over a kitchen, ask **in writing** whether you must remove it when you leave. Some contracts make you restore the flat to its original empty state at your own cost.

2 Five questions to ask at the viewing

Say them in German if you can. It signals you are serious, and landlords choosing between twenty applicants notice that.

1 Is a fitted kitchen included?

Ist eine Einbauküche enthalten?

If the answer is no, follow up with

Kann ich die Küche vom Vermieter übernehmen? — can I take over the kitchen from the previous tenant?

2 How high are the extra costs, and what do they include?

Wie hoch sind die Nebenkosten, und was ist darin enthalten?

Rent is quoted two ways. **Kaltmiete** is the bare rent. **Warmmiete** adds Nebenkosten — heating, water, rubbish. **Electricity and internet are usually not included**, so budget €40–€70 a month on top for those.

3 Will I get the landlord's confirmation for city registration?

Bekomme ich eine Wohnungsgeberbestätigung für die Anmeldung?

This is the single most important question on the list. Without this signed form you **cannot register your address**, and without registration you cannot get a tax ID, a bank account, or in many cases your residence permit. A landlord who hesitates here is a serious warning sign.

4 How much is the deposit, and can I pay it in three instalments?

Wie hoch ist die Kautiön, und kann ich sie in drei Raten zahlen?

German law caps the deposit at **three months of Kaltmiete**, and you have the legal right to split it across three monthly payments. Anyone demanding more than three months, or demanding it all in cash, is either uninformed or not legitimate.

5 Are there ceiling lamps and flooring, and do I have to redecorate when I leave?

Sind Lampen und Bodenbelag vorhanden? Muss ich beim Auszug renovieren?

Redecoration clauses (**Schönheitsreparaturen**) can mean repainting the whole flat at your expense on the way out. Many such clauses have been struck down by German courts, but you want to know what is written before you sign, not after.

3 Where to actually search

Studierendenwerk CHEAPEST

Your university city's official student housing body. Dorm rooms are the cheapest legitimate option, often €250–€400 warm. The catch is the waiting list, which runs one to three semesters in popular cities. **Apply the day you get your admission letter**, not the day you arrive.

[studentenwerke.de](https://www.studentenwerke.de)

WG-Gesucht MOST LISTINGS

The default site for shared flats (**WG**) and the largest pool of student-friendly rooms in Germany. Expect competition: good rooms get fifty messages in an hour, and you will be invited to a viewing that is effectively an interview.

[wg-gesucht.de](https://www.wg-gesucht.de)

Wunderflats FURNISHED

Verified furnished flats rented for one month or longer, with contracts written in English and registration-ready paperwork. You pay a premium for that safety. Sensible as a **landing pad for your first one to three months** while you search properly from inside the country.

[wunderflats.com](https://www.wunderflats.com)

ImmoScout24 & Immowelt WHOLE FLATS

The mainstream property portals, mostly for entire apartments rather than rooms. Listings are almost all in German and landlords typically want proof of income, which is hard as a new student. Useful once you have a job or a guarantor.

[immobilienscout24.de](https://www.immobilienscout24.de)

Non-negotiable rule

Never transfer money and never send your passport scan before you have **seen the flat** — in person or on a live video call — **and signed a**

contract. Any story that ends with "send the deposit first and I will post the keys" is a scam. There are no exceptions to this, however convincing the listing looks.

4 Your first day in an empty flat

1 Buy light before dark

If there are bare wires hanging from the ceiling, you have no light after sunset — and in a German winter that is around four in the afternoon. Get a cheap **plug-in floor lamp or clip lamp** and bulbs from any DIY store on day one. Do not wire a ceiling fixture yourself unless you know exactly what you are doing.

2 Put your name on the letterbox and doorbell

German post is not delivered to flat numbers. It is delivered to **names**. If your name is not on the **Briefkasten** and the **Klingelschild**, your residence permit, bank card and university letters go back to sender. A printed label strip is fine on day one — ask the landlord before drilling or sticking anything permanent.

3 Photograph every flaw and file the handover protocol

Before you unpack, photograph every scratch, stain, damp mark and broken fitting, with the date visible. Make sure it all goes into the **Übergabeprotokoll** — the handover record — and that both of you sign it. This document is what stands between you and losing your deposit two years from now.

Same week, not same day

Register your electricity with a provider, and book your **Anmeldung** appointment. Both are easy to forget in the chaos of moving, and both have deadlines attached.

An empty flat is not a bad flat

It is a flat that expects you to arrive prepared. Ask the five questions, keep your deposit money out of strangers' hands, and buy a lamp on day one. Everything after that is just furniture.

Deposit and registration rules described here are federal German law (BGB §551, BMG §19). Prices are typical ranges, not guarantees, and vary widely by city. Confirm anything contractual with a tenants' association (**Mieterverein**) before signing. Last reviewed September 2026.

Going to a viewing this week? Save this page and open it on your phone while you are there.

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